

B. SANTHANAM | CEO, ASIA-PACIFIC & INDIA REGION | SAINT-GOBAIN INDIA

Saint-Gobain is a designer, manufacturer and distributor of construction material



122 |

“Seek feedback and incorporate it”

What was the problem you were grappling with?

Back in the day, I was grappling with a difference of opinion with my team. I was using the same yardstick with everyone around me.

This came to light during an annual conference, where several members spoke about the unrelenting pressure that was being exerted.

I had just taken over the leadership role and my style was quite intense. The feedback came as a rude shock.

Whom did you approach for advice and why?

Although I did not approach him directly, Anand (Mahajan, who was the Managing Director then and later became Chairman of the company), being the perceptive leader that he was, noticed that I was disturbed.

He did not voice any opinion in public, was sensitive and without being intrusive, suggested a shift in my leadership approach.

What was the advice you received?

Anand advised me to listen, learn, and adapt. He expressed confidence that I would overcome the business challenges in future.

How effective was it in resolving the problem?

That advice made me rethink my leadership style. And after that, I brought about several changes in terms of democracy, inclusion, etc., in the workplace.

It has been over four decades now [since I received that advice], but I believe it was life-changing for me at a professional level and continues to be the same to date.

I also learnt from Anand that a leader needs to be empathetic and not assume that everyone would have the same level of aspiration that a leader has. A leader should also be open to seeking feedback and incorporating it. **BT**

—TEAM **BT**

Vol. 33, No. 13 for the fortnight

June 10, 2024 to June 23, 2024.

Released on June 10, 2024.

Total number of pages 124 (including cover)